every year, Caracalla inherited power from his father, Septimius Severus, who became emperor by winning a civil war. The most important step Caracalla took to cement his rule was murdering his brother and rival, Geta.

When Caracalla ordered the murder of Geta, declared war on the Parthian Empire or extended Roman citizenship to millions of Britons, Greeks and Arabs, he had no need to ask permission from the Roman people. All of Rome's self-correcting mechanisms had been neutralised long before. If Caracalla made some error in foreign or domestic policy, neither the Senate nor any officials could intervene to correct it, except by rising in rebellion or assassinating him. And when Caracalla was indeed assassinated in 217, it only led to a new round of civil wars culminating in the rise of new autocrats. Rome in the third century CE, like Russia in the eighteenth century, was, in the words of Madame de Staël, 'autocracy tempered by strangulation'.

By the third century CE, not only the Roman Empire but all other major human societies on earth were centralised information networks lacking strong self-correcting mechanisms. This was true of the Parthian and Sassanian Empires in Persia, of the Kushan and Gupta Empires in India, and of China's Han Empire and its successor Three Kingdoms.[26] Thousands of more small-scale societies continued to function democratically in the third century CE and beyond, but it seemed that distributed democratic networks were simply incompatible with large-scale societies.

CAESAR FOR PRESIDENT!

Were large-scale democracies really unworkable in the ancient world? Or did autocrats like Augustus and Caracalla deliberately sabotage them? This question is important not only for our understanding of ancient history but also for our view of democracy's future in the age of AI. How do we know whether democracies fail because they are undermined by strongmen or because of much deeper structural and technological reasons?

To answer that question, let's take a closer look at the Roman Empire. The Romans were clearly familiar with the democratic ideal, and it continued to be important to them even after the Caesar family rose to power. Otherwise, Augustus and his heirs would not have bothered to